

10-Year Report

2025

vmf COLLECTIVE | village micro fund

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Letter from the Founders

From the beginning, **Village Micro Fund** set out to do what the world often said was impossible for Black folks—build trust, build wealth, and build something that would last. This wasn't just about handing out loans or offering the occasional workshop. It was about reclaiming our narrative, rewriting the script on who we are and what we can do in this world that's historically been engineered to deny us. We started with something simple— a **crowdfunded loan** for Westview Pizza Café. The loan wasn't just dollars moving from hand to hand;it was the beginning of something much bigger, a symbol that Black people can be our own bank, our own investors, our own support system.

Through the Flourish Fellowship, we took that narrative and wove it into the stories of over **200 founders** across **13 cohorts**, we leveraged the collective power of our community.

We didn't just talk about money and business models either. We dug deeper to see the whole entrepreneur, providing mentors, **Founders Therapy** and **Financial Therapy**, because the weight of the responsibility resting on their shoulders requires more than just numbers to carry it. It isn't just a fellowship, but a family. A family that has seen **alumni go from mom and pop shops to shelves of Walmart**, a feat that echoes louder than just dollars—it reverberates through the history of a people told to dream small. And yet, here we are, dreaming big and making dreams a reality. We are our own greatest asset, and we are not waiting for permission to invest in ourselves.

The current financial system was built to meet the needs of the people that created it, and that's why we're building something new. We don't just envision a future—we're creating one. Over the next decade, we will establish

HOW WE STARTED...



WHERE WE ARE NOW



a **parallel financial ecosystem**, one that runs on our cooperative values; **redefining finance** for Black communities and creating a system that honors our history, reflects our culture, and secures our future. In this new world we're building, we're not just participants in the economy—**we are the architects.**

We see a future where Black communities aren't merely **struggling to survive** but are **thriving**, where the brilliance of our people is fully realized and our economic destiny is finally in our hands.

We will create wealth, not just for ourselves, but for generations to come. This is the future of the Village, and we invite you to **join us in building it**.

Donte & Harriett

Founders of VMF Collective

Meet the Village

Village Micro Fund

a social impact fund weaving together capital, community, and our curriculum; where the ancient principles of cooperative economics meet cutting-edge technology to create something revolutionary: a truly equitable investment model.

The Flourish Fellowship | Opening session





The Flourish Fellowship | Mentorship Dinner





The Flourish Fellowship | Graduation







Teach: Flourish Fellowship

We're building an ecosystem where Black businesses don't just survive - they flourish; beginning with our 15-week Flourish Fellowship. Here, we fill gaps in business knowledge and then connect them to the people and resources they need to amplify their impact. Our fellows dive deep into practical skills while connecting to a legacy of cooperative economic thought and innovation. Each cohort becomes a family, challenging and supporting each other through intensive learning, strategic planning, and personal growth.

The Flourish Fellowship Experience

Opening Session: Fellows join our village of partners, alumni, and supporters for their introduction to the program through a vibrant community gathering. This session establishes the foundational relationships that will support their entrepreneurial journey.

Custom comprehensive Curriculum: Our field-tested curriculum centers on the business model canvas, developed through years of entrepreneur feedback. It delivers essential knowledge in customer discovery, legal frameworks, financial management, marketing strategy, fundraising, sales techniques, and team leadership.

Mentorship Dinner: We pair each fellow with industry-aligned mentors from our alumni network and business community over a dinner. These relationships connect fellows with potential customers, industry expertise, and strategic guidance to accelerate their growth.

Graduation: The program culminates in a celebration where fellows compete in a pitch competition for grant capital and potential investment. This event brings together our entire ecosystem - alumni, partners, funders, and families - to launch our newest entrepreneurs into their next phase of growth.

Investments

Our investments are more than transactions; they're covenants. We structure deals that recognize the unique challenges and opportunities within Black businesses, creating terms that align with real growth patterns and community values. This isn't charity - it's strategic investment in the future of Black wealth creation.

Capital Access Partnerships

We've built strategic partnerships to create comprehensive funding pathways for our entrepreneurs:

KIVA Partnership: As Atlanta's KIVA Hub since 2020, we facilitate 0% interest loans for entrepreneurs citywide. Our team guides founders through the entire process - from campaign creation to post-funding support. Through partnerships with LISC Atlanta, Kindred Futures (formally AWBI), and Partnership for Southern Equity (PSE), we have provided matching funds of up 50% of each loan, accelerating our entrepreneurs; path to funding success.

Access to Capital for Entrepreneurs (ACE): Our long-standing partnership with ACE, initiated through the 2016 ASCEND Atlanta program with JP Morgan, Morehouse College, Tech Square Labs, and Kindred Futures (formerly AWBI), has channeled over $500,000 in character-based loans to our graduates. This collaboration demonstrates the power of character-based lending in supporting underserved entrepreneurs.

Entrepreneurs of Color Fund: As members of this $500M initiative with LISC and JP Morgan, we join 23 CDFIs across 10 cities in expanding capital access for entrepreneurs of color. Our pre-CDFI status, with plans to become a full CDFI, positions us to further increase our impact in providing accessible, equitable financing options for our community.

Test Lab

Between the dreams of Black entrepreneurs and the realities of systemic barriers lies a truth we cannot ignore: traditional funding models weren't built for us. But in that gap, we found our purpose through being the architects and testers of new financial systems. By fusing time-tested cooperative economic principles with blockchain technology and artificial intelligence, we're creating investment models that honor both profit and purpose.

Worker's Equity Fund

The Worker's Equity Fund is our alternative to the traditional Private Equity Fund. We invest in a business, support its growth for 4-5 years, and then sell it back to the employees who power it. They purchase ownership not through outside capital, but through the profits they now share; reimagining labor and ownership.

EnDAO

The **Community DAO** (**Decentralized Autonomous Organization**) is a digital governance system that puts economic power directly in community hands. It functions as a collectively-owned and democratically-managed investment fund where neighborhood residents can propose, vote on, and implement local economic initiatives.

Through the DAO, community members can:

1. Propose and vote on community investments
2. Purchase and manage shared property
3. Fund new local businesses
4. Support neighborhood services and programs
5. Participate in transparent decision-making

All decisions and transactions are recorded on a blockchain, ensuring transparency and accountability. This structure transforms traditional economic power dynamics by putting investment decisions and resource allocation under direct community control, while building collective wealth that remains in the neighborhood. This model represents a practical alternative to financial exclusion, where economic power and decision-making are distributed among community members rather than concentrated in traditional institutions

vmf COLLECTIVE

- TEACH
- INVEST
- SUPPORT

- FLOURISH FELLOW
  - LICENSING
- WORKSHOPS
- INVESTOR ED
- DEBT
  - LOAN FUND
  - VILLAGE SEED
- EQUITY
  - WE FUND
  - SSC DAO
- GRIOT HOUSE
  - TRADING GRIOT
  - DREAMSCAPE
- COMMUNITY DAO
  - TIME BANK
  - DAO APP
- COMMUNITY
  - CONFERENCE
  - ALUMNI ASSC

Village Impact

To date, we've been able to graduate **OVER 200 ALUMNI** from our Flourish Fellowship that collectively generate **$20M ANNUALLY**, all while distributing **OVER $3.52M IN FUNDING** to **OVER 100 SMALL BUSINESSES**, creating **492 JOBS**, and touching **OVER 411 FOUNDERS** through our programming.

Businesses Represented

Health/ Fitness, Consulting, Events, Fashion, Social Good, Sewing Education, Food Products, Art, Hospitality, Travel, Finance, Retail Products, Jewelry, Watches, Farming, Music, Commercial Kitchen, Hair Care, Engineering, AR/VR/Art, Child Education, Fashion, Skincare, Food Catering, Tea/Coffee, Retail Services, Business Services, Tech, Film, Product Consulting, Design, Transportation, Art Mental Health Services, Finance, Sewing/Embroidery services, Real Estate, Healthcare Consulting/Education, Media, Public Relations, Podcast Production, Advertising, Printing, App Development, Photography, Eyeware, Accounting, Music Education, Brewery, Marketing, Games, Beauty & Wellness, Greeting Cards, Farming, and Restaurants

Awards Received

FORBES MAGAZINE 30 under 30 Social Impact Honoree
ECHOING GREEN FELLOW - Class of 2022
RESOLUTION PROJECT - Geraldine Acuna Sunshine Young Leaders Now Award
SIGGIE AWARD - Conscious Capital
CENTER FOR CIVIC INNOVATION Good Trouble Award
EMORY COLLEGE Board of Visitors
UGA GA BULLDOGS 2023 - 100 Fastest Growing Companies
ATLANTA MAGAZINE - 500 Most Powerful Leaders 21-24
GA TREND 500 Most Powerful Leaders 23-24
LISC RUBINGER FELLOW 2021
BOSTON IMPACT INITIATIVES FELLOW 2021
UNIVERSITY OF GEORGIA - 40 under 40 honoree

Partners

Walmart
J.P.Morgan
Microsoft
TARGET
Rice Business Russell Innovation Center for Entrepreneurs
Atlanta Beltline
LISC ATLANTA
mailchimp
The Annie E. Casey Foundation
Kindred Futures
kiva
United Way of Greater Atlanta
Humanity United
The Kendeda Fund
MIEC
Atlanta Blockchain Center
Atlanta Hawks
ACE
Urban League of Greater Atlanta
Community Foundation for Greater Atlanta
Partnership for Southern Equity
Together We Prosper
INVESTATLANTA
COMCAST
Delta Community Credit Union

Press



NBC Unites Creative Impact Lab Showing at Paralympics
https://bit.ly/40KZGuG



Samsung x Forbes
https://bit.ly/40pnNxC



Google Blog
https://bit.ly/3WzkBS



Morgan Stanley - Mind the Gap: A Guide to Advancing Racial Equity through Philanthropy
https://bit.ly/3Ww3FIY



Bitter Southerner
https://bit.ly/3WCsJ18

Success Stories.





Tiffany Ellis of G'Ann's Cold Pressed Juices



Walmart Retail Readiness Cohort Partnership Winner

Teach.

For **April Jackson**, a **2022 Flourish Fellow and founder of PASS Network,** our support made all the difference. PASS Network brings personalized learning to kids in underserved communities in South Atlanta through micro schools. When April joined the Village, her school was down to just one student and needed a total reset. **"VMF helped me see my business in a new way,"** she recalls. **"I thought of it as a nonprofit, but they helped me see that PASS Network was a for-profit business, and I needed to treat it like one."** This shift in perspective inspired April to rebrand PASS Network, and it didn't stop there. The community-driven approach she saw at VMF led her to co-found Black Micro Schools ATL, a coalition of 17 independently owned micro schools in Atlanta. **"That idea of moving together and working together, I got that from the Village,"** she says. **"You all helped me see that our impact could be so much stronger if we worked as a collective."**

Tiffany Ellis, a **2023 Flourish Fellow** and **founder of G'Ann's Cold Pressed Juices,** saw transformation with her wellness brand during our Walmart Retail Readiness Cohort with Kindred Futures. Tiffany, with years of corporate experience, joined our Flourish Fellowship, believing it would be enough to propel her business to where she envisioned. **"VMF humbled me in the best way,"** she laughs. **"I thought I knew business, but they taught me how different it is to work on your business versus just working in it."** With VMF's guidance, Tiffany took a step back to lay a stronger foundation. **"VMF taught me to step out of day-to-day tasks and really think about where my business was going,"** she shares. Winning the capstone pitch competition and $25,000 at the end of the fellowship helped her reinvest in her brand, from rebranding to revamping her website. **"Winning that pitch competition was a bonus,"** she says. **"It gave me the resources I needed, but most importantly, I left with friends and mentors I can still call on today. The Village is forever."**

Walmart Retail Readiness Cohort - Our latest Flourish Fellowship, powered by Kindred Futures, supported 20 Black-owned businesses in a 15-week program. Entrepreneurs received intensive training and mentorship, resulting in $75,000 in graduation grants.

The big win?

Two of our businesses landed Walmart contracts, turning potential into real opportunity. This cohort proves that with the right support, Black entrepreneurs can break through barriers and secure major retail partnerships.

Invest.

A Kitchen, A Community, A Revolution: Keitra's Journey



In 2014, we met **Keitra**, founder of **Westview Pizza Cafe** - now known as **Marddy's** - an entrepreneur whose vision would become the first thread in our community investment tapestry. Her restaurant, Westview Pizza Cafe, was more than a business; it was a bridge in a neighborhood being reshaped by gentrification, a place where long-time residents and newcomers could break bread and build understanding, however running a mission-driven business requires more than passion. Keitra needed practical support - a new stove, precise accounting, and most critically, capital that understood her vision. Where traditional funding models would have seen risk, we saw potential. Working together, we decoded her true food costs, connected her to local college students, and pioneered something groundbreaking: **Georgia's first community-funded small business loan.** Through crowdfunding, we raised $5,000 directly from her neighborhood - proving that communities will invest in their own when given the right tools. The loan was a testament to collective power, and at the end of the term, every investor received what they invested plus 5% interest, proving that community capital can transform a neighborhood, one kitchen, one business at a time. Keitra was our first client and our proof; when communities invest in themselves, everyone wins.

Over Covid, we became KIVA Hub and invested over $2.1M in grants to local business

When COVID-19 hit, small businesses across metro Atlanta faced an impossible choice: survive or close forever. We didn't just stand by—we took action, building multiple lifelines across diverse communities. In City of Atlanta, we partnered with the **Atlanta Wealth Building Initiative** (**AWBI**) to deliver targeted grants to local businesses. That served strategic investments in the city's economic survival. Meanwhile, we worked directly with the City of South Fulton to create a separate grant program for $500k specifically supporting businesses in that community. During that time, we also became a hub for **KIVA**, a crowdfunding platform that provides 0% interest loans, we processed all their Atlanta loans while adding another crucial funding source. KIVA allowed us to tap into community support, with individuals directly investing in local businesses through small, zero-interest loans. Across these three programs - AWBI, South Fulton's local grants, and KIVA crowdfunding - we mobilized **$2.1 million in support.** Hundreds of businesses survived, and as a result, entire neighborhoods were sustained. When the world shut down, we stepped up with one mission; to keep our local businesses alive, and we did just that.

From Prison to Produce: The G2G Story



In 2018, **Abiodun Henderson** confronted a harsh reality facing Atlanta's formerly incarcerated youth: over 50% return to the justice system within three years. This wasn't just a statistic to her - it represented lives interrupted and potential stolen. From this challenge, **Gangstas to Growers** (**G2G**) was born, a program that uses agriculture as a transformative tool for personal and professional development. Partnering with the **Southwest Atlanta Grower's Co-op** (**SWAG**), a network of 18 urban farmers, G2G created a comprehensive program that goes far beyond job training. Young people learn agricultural skills, business development, leadership, and life strategies while producing Sweet Sol hot sauce directly from the farms they work. Every member receives professional training, business workshops, a living wage, and a path to business ownership.

Through our Worker's Equity Fund, we recognized the potential in her vision while most investors saw only risk invested in the business with the explicit goal of eventually transferring ownership to the employees themselves. This wasn't charity - it was a strategic investment in human potential, creating a model where young people aren't just workers, but future business owners.

Soon after our investment, G2G was able to earn an $1M investment from Jeff Bezos and recognition from Shaquille O'Neal, but for Abbey, the true victory was more personal; it was every young person who stayed out of prison, learned a trade, and saw a different future for themselves. To date, G2G has touched hundreds of formerly incarcerated youth, produced thousands of hot sauce bottles, and created a replicable model for youth economic empowerment.

More than a business, G2G proves that investment is about believing in people. It demonstrates how creating supportive systems can provide second chances, show young people their inherent value, and build pathways to economic independence. One hot sauce at a time, they're not just changing individual lives - they're challenging systemic barriers and reimagining what's possible for communities often overlooked and underestimated.

Support.

Building Connections, Meeting Needs: How the Village Brings Entrepreneurs Together for Growth E Mackey and Victoria - Alumni and Experts

In the Village, we've created a network where Black entrepreneurs connect, collaborate, and support each other. These connections often emerge in unexpected moments, transforming individual challenges into collective opportunities.

E. Mackey is the founder of **Black Spades,** and his time throughout and after the Flourish Fellowship illustrates this perfectly. Before VMF, he understood pitching but not the nuanced art of building a business. "**I didn't really know how businesses got money,**" he recalls. "**I knew how to pitch, but not how to pitch a business—there's a difference.**"

The program reshaped his entire approach. His mindset shifted from developing playing cards to developing an app to have a place where his community can come together and play their favorite card games. He got an opportunity to actualize that at a Village alumni event where a chance encounter would change everything.

Walking in late, frustrated with his current app developer, Mackey overheard **Victoria Walker** explaining her work. **Victoria,** founder of **Vivify Solutions,** specializes in custom software development.

"**Someone stopped her to talk, and as I overheard her explaining what she does, it just clicked,**" Mackey says. "**She was exactly who I needed on my team.**"

Their connection was immediate and organic. What began as a brief conversation at an event turned into a, literally, game-changing collaboration. Victoria took over the development of Mackey's app, bringing expertise that transformed his original vision.

"**VMF has changed the way I approach everything,**" Mackey reflects. "**Without it, I probably wouldn't have been ready to build this app, much less with a teammate like Victoria.**"

This is the VMF difference. More than an incubator, it's a living, breathing ecosystem where entrepreneurs find funding, and fundamental support; where a random conversation can become a business breakthrough and community isn't just a word—it's a strategic advantage.

In the Village, our relationships don't just end after the cohort; we grow together, solve together, and succeed together as a community.

Resilience in Action: How the Village and Community Support Sustained Just Add Honey through Crisis



For **Brandi Shelton,** founder of **Just Add Honey,** community isn't just a value—it's the foundation that held her business together during one of the most challenging periods in recent history. **Just Add Honey**, a brand dedicated to bringing fresh, thoughtfully blended teas to its customers, **faced unexpected hardships as the COVID-19 pandemic swept through.** With three retail locations, a full production facility, and a staff of 26 people, Brandi was on the verge of launching a fourth store when everything shifted in 2020. "**We were getting ready to expand when the world turned upside down,**" she recalls.

Through her connection to VMF, Brandi found the support and resources her business needed to weather the storm. VMF introduced her to **Kindred Futures** (formerly Atlanta Wealth Building Initiative), a community partner dedicated to redefining wealth for Black people across the South by investing in Black wealth solution providers. Focused on creating a just and inclusive economy, Kindred Futures shares VMF's dedication to empowering Black-owned businesses through financial and community-driven resilience. For Brandi, receiving that grant was about more than just keeping the lights on—it was about honoring her values and the commitment to her team and community. "**When I think about what kept us going, the Village was a huge piece of that pie,**" she says. "**Between an amazing team, an amazing foundation, and an amazing community, we had what we needed to withstand COVID's ups and downs.**"

As Brandi navigated an uncertain landscape, her dedication to her team never wavered. "Our rent was non-negotiable, and our team depended on us," she says. "**So, while guidance from the top felt murky, we got creative.**" Knowing that many of her employees were recent graduates without the safety net of unemployment, Brandi found ways to keep them engaged, asking them to write blog posts or contribute in other ways.

Operating from their locations at Sweet Auburn Curb Market, Avalon, and their production facility in Tucker, GA, Just Add Honey faced logistical challenges, from decreased foot traffic to unreliable public transportation. "**Our store in Sweet Auburn, for example, would see maybe three customers on a good day,**" Brandi explains. "**We'd have to pay staff just to show up, even if no one was coming in. Our production team in Tucker was dealing with bus routes that barely ran, so sometimes just getting employees to work meant covering Uber rides that cut into their pay.**" The grant provided financial breathing room, allowing her to maintain staff support and keep essential bills paid through those unpredictable months.

Ultimately, Brandi sees the support from Village and Kindred Futures as an extension of her commitment to the people who make Just Add Honey what it is. "**We wanted to do right by our people, the ones who showed up for us through thick and thin,**" she says. "**Nothing feels worse than talking big and hiding under the pillow. VMF and Kindred Futures allowed us to keep doing right by the folks in our 'pie' and stay good stewards to the community and team that believed in us.**"

In a time of crisis, the Village and partners like Kindred Futures proved that investing in local businesses means more than just financial support; it's about preserving community values and helping entrepreneurs stay true to their vision. **For Brandi and Just Add Honey, this support made all the difference, allowing them to keep their business alive and continue bringing quality teas—and quality connections—to the community.**

Support.

Southwest Atlanta Growers (SWAG) Feasibility Study for Farmer's Cooperativeand Chef Off using Patchwork Farms ingredients



In the heart of Southwest Atlanta, 18 urban farmers faced a common challenge. Each farm, typically just 1-2 acres, was too small to compete in a market designed for industrial agriculture. Individually, they were vulnerable. Together, they could be powerful.

This led them to create the **Southwest Atlanta Growers Cooperative** (**SWAG**), which was born from by a shared desire to transform how food is produced, distributed, and celebrated in their neighborhood.

In 2018, the Village worked with SWAG to work on a comprehensive feasibility study with the goal to map out a new future. By documenting each farm's resources and needs, they discovered something profound. Collectively, these 18 farms represented 26 acres of potential; potential for sustainable agriculture, community connection, and economic resilience.

In order to achieve their vision of a shared Community Supported Agriculture (CSA) model, they needed to coordinate crop planning, share expensive equipment, and pool their purchasing power. Through collaboration, these farmers could punch above their weight class; individually overlooked, but collectively undeniable.

Later that year, we launched our inaugural cooking competition that we later named Soulfood Symphony in partnership with SWAG. Imagine 9 local chefs, competing with ingredients sourced entirely from one of our local farms, Patchwork City Farms - led by Jamila Norman, SWAG's president and star of Homegrown, a gardening show on HBO. It brought together farmers, chefs, food producers, and our Village, creating a space to honor the labor of the land while building bridges between consumers and the people who feed them. The event amplified the voices of local farmers and chefs while planting the seeds of awareness about the importance of supporting Atlanta's urban agriculture.

SWAG represents more than agriculture. It's a blueprint for community-driven economic development. It shows how collaboration can transform limitations into opportunities and how small farms can become a powerful collective voice. In a food system designed to push out small producers, SWAG plants seeds of resistance - one acre, one harvest at a time.



















History of the Village

2013 ORIGINS

- Village concept launched with first workshop
- Began developing community-based finance model

2014 FOUNDATION

- First client partnership: Westview Pizza Cafe (WVPC)
- Inaugural cohort of 9 entrepreneurs at Morehouse campus
- Achieved 501(c)(3) status

2015 INNOVATION

- Created Georgia's first crowdfunded small business loan for WVPC
- Selected for Village Capital accelerator, expanding network

2016 - 2017 INSTITUTIONAL GROWTH

- Formed strategic partnerships with Truly Living Well, Morehouse, ACE Loans, JP Morgan (Ascend 2020)
- Secured foundational funding from Kendeda Fund and Annie E Casey
- Created first Village Curriculum
- Joined AWBI (now Kindred Futures) Community of Practice
- Launched character-based lending program with ACE
- First full-time team members hired

2018 - 2019 PROGRAM DEVELOPMENT

- Led specialized SuperBowl cohort focusing on Art and Food entrepreneurs
- Conducted Southwest Atlanta Growers Cooperative (SWAG) feasibility study
- Reached milestone of 10th cohort completion
- Explored mixed capital fund model

2020 CRISIS RESPONSE & INNOVATION

- Designed and piloted Workers' Equity Fund
- Partnered with HEY! and Partnership for Southern Equity for Atlanta Waterboys
- Graduated youngest founder (Mason Super Dogs, age 15)
- Coordinated $1.8M COVID relief with AWBI and City of South Fulton
- Joined JP Morgan and LISC's Entrepreneurs of Color Fund (EOCF)

2021 NATIONAL RECOGNITION

- Featured in Morgan Stanley's Guide to Addressing Racial Equity
- Highlighted by Google.org during Black History Month
- Supported by JP Morgan Virtual Service Corps
- Selected for multiple fellowships: Boston Impact Initiative, Rubinger, Common Future
- Donte named Forbes 30 Under 30 in Social Impact

2022 INTERNATIONAL GROWTH

- Initiated Cape Town, South Africa partnership
- Successfully launched Workers Equity Fund investment G2G
- Featured in Mailchimp/NFL Give Where You Live Campaign
- Became Atlanta's KIVA Hub
- Selected for Hawks Social Impact Council
- Joined Echoing Green Fellowship

2023 SCALING IMPACT

- Walmart Retail Cohort success: $75k granted, retail placement achieved
- NBCU network commercial feature
- Harriett recognized: UGA Bulldog 100 and 40 under 40
- Expanded South African presence with multiple visits
- Joined Emory Board of Visitors

2024 INNOVATION & SCALE

- Launched EnDAO community platform MVP
- Samsung/Forbes recognition for community leadership
- Completed Echoing Green Fellowship
- Led Comcast RISE Program partnership
- Developed new participatory grantmaking model with Humanity United
- Established African retail pipeline
- Registered as South African NPO
- Secured MOUs with multiple African institutions

Vision for the Future
THE NEXT 10 YEARS

Parallel Financial System

We stand at a critical moment in economic history. The traditional financial system has never been designed for Black communities - it has been a tool of extraction, not empowerment. Our current reality is brutal: millennials facing retirement dreams slipping away, Black residents in Atlanta struggling with less than $2,000 in savings, and an economic model that values capital over human potential. But we see something different. We see a path forward.

Our journey begins by understanding that wealth is more than money. Wealth is talent, culture, community. While we may be short on traditional capital, we are rich in the most important currencies: human potential, collective genius, and unbreakable community bonds. The financial system hasn't failed us - it was never built for us in the first place.

We are designing a new economic ecosystem, piece by deliberate piece. The Workers Equity Fund transforms how businesses are owned and operated. Instead of investors extracting value, we create pathways for workers to become owners. We invest in a business, support its growth for 4-5 years, and then sell it back to the employees who power it. They purchase ownership not through outside capital, but through the profits they now share; reimagining of labor and ownership.

Our **Community Decentralized Autonomous Organization** (**DAO**) puts economic power directly into community hands. Imagine a digital fund where any neighborhood resident can propose and vote on investments.



Want to purchase property? Start a community business? Fund direct services? The community decides, democratically and transparently. This isn't theoretical - this is a living, breathing alternative to financial exclusion.

The Time Bank completes our vision, transforming labor itself into a form of investment. Community members earn stakes in collective investments through their work. Your time, your skills, your labor become capital. We're creating investment pathways for those whom traditional systems have locked out, recognizing that value comes in many forms beyond cash.

These aren't just financial models, but a blueprint for economic liberation. In a world where automation threatens jobs and inflation erodes savings, we are building resilience. We are creating systems that see our full humanity, that value community over individual extraction, that transform survival into genuine prosperity.

Existing financial structures persist because they work exclusively for the people they were built for. They lack the imagination to see beyond their current model, but we are not asking for permission. We're building an entirely new economic landscape, where Black communities are not just participants or victims, but architects of their own financial future. This is how we turn generations of economic violence into a future of shared abundance. We can't just wait for the system to change; we have to be the change we want to see; investment by investment, community by community, and dream by dream.

Flourish Fellowship Model for Education

Complementing the Flourish Fellowship model, we've developed a scalable educational approach that turns every graduate into a potential teacher. Our program creates a multiplier effect, where entrepreneurs learn not just to build their own businesses, but to become educators and community leaders, while also serving as a place for us to learn the business and see under the hood for due diligence for potential investments. We provide comprehensive training materials, virtual content, and a certification process that allows our graduates to bring economic education back to their communities. This means our impact extends far beyond the initial 15 weeks - each participant becomes a node in a growing network of economic empowerment.

Our ultimate goal is to create a replicable model of economic education that can be adapted across communities. Each entrepreneur we train becomes a mentor. Each business we support becomes a blueprint. We're building a network that transforms individual success into collective power. This isn't about creating isolated success stories - it's about building an ecosystem where economic knowledge flows freely, where community becomes the most powerful form of capital.

We're creating a new path forward, where financial literacy is a right, not a privilege. Where every person has the tools to build generational wealth. Where the ability to create economic opportunity is distributed, not concentrated. The future of economic education starts here. Not with grand theories or distant promises, but with real people, real skills, and an unwavering belief in our collective potential.

African Trade & Entrepreneurship Initiative

We're creating a entrepreneurial pipeline connecting Atlanta to African markets through a trade and business development program, placing an emphasis on supply chain and manufacturing. At the heart of this initiative is the establishment of a trade center that connects small businesses with manufacturers and mass-market retailers across continents. This hub will streamline supply chains and create direct pathways between African manufacturers and U.S. markets, while opening new opportunities for Atlanta-based entrepreneurs to reach African consumers.

Our Flourish Fellowship program will expand through a parallel course in South Africa, creating a bilateral entrepreneurship accelerator. Fellows from Atlanta and South Africa will collaborate, share insights, and build cross-continental business relationships. Through this exchange, we aim to foster innovation while strengthening economic ties between our regions. This expansion aligns with and builds upon recent developments in Atlanta-South Africa relations, including the Phambili agreement.

To support these efforts locally, we're working on developing a shared business resource hub governed by a neighborhood DAO (Decentralized Autonomous Organization), giving local entrepreneurs direct ownership and decision-making power over the hub's resources and operations. The DAO structure ensures transparent governance while building community wealth through shared ownership.

These interconnected initiatives will create sustainable trade routes between Atlanta and African markets, develop cross-cultural entrepreneurial networks, and establish community-owned business infrastructure. By generating new economic opportunities in both regions, we're building lasting economic bridges while ensuring benefits flow directly to local entrepreneurs and communities.

Atlanta Phambili, meaning "forward" in Zulu and Xhosa, is a subnational diplomacy initiative connecting U.S. and South African leaders, institutions, and businesses. Leveraging Atlanta's educational, creative, and economic strengths, it fosters mutual understanding, shared prosperity, and knowledge exchange. This joint effort by the U.S. Mission in South Africa and the South African government positions Atlanta as a gateway for collaboration.

Pan African DAO Federation

Picture a digital cooperative spanning continents, each point of light a community DAO harnessing with collective power. From Harlem to Haiti, Lagos to London, **autonomous Black communities are weaving an economic web that transcends borders and reclaims sovereignty.**

Each local DAO maintains its unique identity and governance, rooted in neighborhood needs. A community garden project in Brooklyn can instantly connect with agricultural innovators in Ghana. Tech entrepreneurs in Nairobi pool resources with developers in Salvador, Brazil. A cultural center in New Orleans shares knowledge with artists in Johannesburg.

These connections run on smart contracts that honor both autonomy and interdependence. **When one community prospers, the ripples strengthen the whole network**. Investment flows like water, nourishing projects that build Black futures. A solar grid in Kingston, Jamaica generates clean energy; its profits help fund coding programs in Accra.

Time Bank credits become a new form of pan-African currency, allowing skills and labor to flow across borders. A healer in Martinique can exchange expertise with a urban farmer in Ethiopia. Traditional knowledge and futuristic innovation merge, creating new forms of value that transcend colonial economic models.

The federation's distributed governance system draws on African traditions of consensus-building while leveraging blockchain transparency. Decisions about shared resources happen through a dynamic process that respects both local autonomy and collective vision. Elders' wisdom guides deployment of cutting-edge financial tools.

Cultural projects flourish in this new ecosystem. Artists and creators retain ownership of their work while tapping into global support networks. Stories and songs travel the digital griot network, strengthening connections between communities. The federation becomes not just an economic system but a revival and reimagining of Black cultural sovereignty.

Most importantly, this network creates resilience through interdependence. When external systems fail, the federation provides mutual aid and support. Economic shocks are absorbed collectively. Resources can be rapidly mobilized to support communities in crisis. The old extractive systems lose their power as communities build self-determined alternatives.

This isn't just about transaction efficiency - it's about transmuting the very nature of value and community. Each DAO becomes a node in a living system that grows stronger through cooperation rather than competition. The technology serves the timeless human needs for connection, reciprocity, and shared prosperity.

The Pan-African DAO Federation represents a future where economic power flows through networks of trust and shared vision. Not a utopian dream, but a practical framework for liberation - built block by block, byte by byte, by communities claiming their right to self-determination. The future is not just decentralized, but deeply connected.





Ten years ago, we began with a simple truth: our community holds the solutions to our economic future. Today, as we look back on a decade of transformation, we're humbled by the village that has made this journey possible. To our founders who dared to dream, our alumni who return to lift others, our partners who believed in our vision, our funders who invested in possibility, and our families who supported us through late nights and early mornings - your faith and commitment have turned ideas into institutions. What began in Atlanta has grown into an international network of economic empowerment, yet our core mission remains unchanged: to build pathways of prosperity that honor our community's genius. As we step into our next decade, we carry forward the wisdom of our past and the boundless potential of our future. Our greatest asset has always been, and will always be, our people. Together, we're not just building businesses - we're crafting a new economic story, one that puts community at its heart. Thank you for being part of this journey. The future we envision is already taking root, and it grows stronger with every person who joins our village. Can't wait to see what the next 10 brings.

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10-year report